Chapter 7
AI in Supporting LGBTQIA+ Populations

Dget L. Downey and David A. Jenkins

1 Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) has transformed many aspects of daily life. As AI technologies increasingly intersect with social work and human services, it is vital to ensure these systems are designed to address the unique needs of marginalized communities, including lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer/questioning, intersex, and asexual (LGBTQIA+) populations. Despite increased recognition of health and mental healthcare disparities for queer and transgender, gender non-conforming (TGNC) individuals, AI solutions often reflect the same biases that appear in the larger societal context.

Further, this chapter explores how AI can be designed and deployed to effectively support LGBTQIA+ communities by examining the ethical, cultural, and technical considerations that arise when integrating AI into social work practice, emphasizing the need to center queer and trans-lived experiences in both the development and implementation of AI tools. This chapter gives special attention to privacy, cultural sensitivity, and bias mitigation, particularly in the context of increasing surveillance and algorithmic discrimination.

AI can promote and advance equity and inclusion when approached critically and collaboratively (Nixon et al., 2024; Roshanaei et al., 2023). This chapter highlights the tensions and opportunities that AI introduces for LGBTQIA+ social work, drawing from interdisciplinary research in psychology, computer science, queer and gender theory, and public health. By demonstrating and exploring current uses, ethical concerns, and future directions of AI, this chapter offers a roadmap for

D. L. Downey (✉)
Sliver School of Social Work, New York University, New York, NY, USA
e-mail: dld382@nyu.edu

D. A. Jenkins
The Ohio State University, Ohio State University, Columbus, OH, USA
e-mail: jenkins.1443@osu.edu

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technologists, researchers, and practitioners seeking to build AI that affirms and protects LGBTQIA+ lives.

1.1 The Problem of Algorithmic Bias Against LGBTQIA+ Communities

Bias in AI is not an accident; it is a product of data infrastructures, technical design choices, and institutional power dynamics (Arora et al., 2023; Scatiggio, 2022). Oyeniran et al. (2022) categorized several types of bias relevant to LGBTQIA+ communities, including label bias, measurement bias, and historical bias, each of which can distort how LGBTQIA+ people are identified, evaluated, and served by algorithms. For example, predictive models in mental health or social service platforms may misinterpret sexual or gender identity markers as anomalies or risk factors (e.g., suicide or mental illness risk), leading to harmful misclassification or denial of care.

Kuhlman et al. (2020) emphasized that such harms are particularly severe when AI systems are used in public health and social welfare contexts. In these spaces, algorithmic decisions are often treated as objective, even when they encode existing disparities. Their paper advocated for "no computation without representation"—a principle that demands LGBTQIA+ inclusion not only as data subjects but as co-developers of systems that affect their lives.

This problem is compounded by the fact that AI systems frequently rely on data that erases or misrepresents LGBTQIA+ identities (Katyal & Jung, 2021). Myles et al. (2023a) mapped the "algorithmic imaginary" imposed by platform companies, where queer content is often flagged as inappropriate. In their study of platform moderation and surveillance, they show how social media platforms use opaque algorithms that sort LGBTQIA+ lives into categories that serve advertising and control—not safety or care.

1.1.1 From Queering Algorithmic Imaginaries to Ethical Re-Design

To disrupt this trend, researchers and advocates argue for a queering of algorithmic imaginaries (Chartrand & Duguay, 2025). Myles et al. (2023b) suggested that LGBTQIA+ people must not only be consulted but also empowered to reimagine what AI systems can do—and what they should be prevented from doing. This includes questioning outcomes and assumptions that shape what gets measured, modeled, and acted upon.

A key insight from this work is that ethical AI cannot be limited to technical fairness metrics. As Sloane (2019) argued, the current AI ethics discourse often functions as a "smokescreen" for real accountability. Tech companies may adopt fairness toolkits or publish diversity statements without addressing the deeper political and economic structures that shape inequality. Sloane called for an ethics agenda that centers power analysis, participatory design, and structural change.

This view aligns closely with social work ethics, as it is also grounded in the principles of dignity, equity, and self-determination. They ask: Does this system reinforce marginalization? Does it increase autonomy for those who have historically been denied it? Who decides how this technology is used, and to what end?

1.1.2 Structural Inequality, Representation, and Social Context

Bias in AI systems may seem like a technical flaw, but it reflects longstanding social hierarchies (Zajko, 2022). As Kuhlman et al. (2020) noted, machine learning models are shaped by the historical exclusion of marginalized voices from data science and public policy. Underrepresentation in datasets, lack of LGBTQIA+ experts and community members in development teams, and the prioritization of efficiency over equity all contribute to systems that fail LGBTQIA+ users.

This structural perspective is vital for computational social science, AI research, and social work practice. Rather than framing inclusion as a data-labeling task or a means to an end, scholars must interrogate how identities intersect within the architecture of AI. Myles et al. (2023a) emphasized the importance of queering algorithmic systems not just at the levels of application and intervention but at the level of epistemology.

For example, content moderation algorithms suppress LGBTQIA+ speech under the guise of "safety" (Sulmicelli, 2023). Studies show that these tools reproduce societal stigma by treating LGBTQIA+ identity as risky, offensive, or adult-only. This is not just a misclassification issue—it is a form of digital violence that echoes long histories of surveillance and silencing.

1.1.3 Toward Ethical, Community-Governed AI Systems

To build AI systems that serve LGBTQIA+ communities equitably, scholars and practitioners must shift from reactive fairness fixes to proactive justice-oriented design. That means centering the needs, expertise, and leadership of LGBTQIA+ people in every stage of system development. Participatory and community-driven approaches—like those advocated by Queer in AI and other grassroots tech justice groups—offer models for this work.

Social work provides a robust foundation for guiding these efforts. Its ethical frameworks prioritize the protection of vulnerable groups, the right to self-determination, and a holistic understanding of human experience. In an AI context, this translates to tools that are: 1) context-aware (i.e., designed with an understanding of the structural forces affecting users), 2) transparent and accountable (i.e., with visible mechanisms for redress and oversight), 3) dynamic (able to evolve as understandings of identity and oppression shift over time), and 4) governed via participatory methods to encourage and reorient control to those most impacted.

While technological fixes can address some biases, lasting change will require institutional and epistemic transformation. That includes rethinking funding priorities, revising education and hiring practices in STEM fields, and challenging dominant narratives that treat marginalized communities as “edge cases” rather than as those to be centered.

1.1.4 Ethics as Praxis, Not Performance

Promoting ethical and inclusive AI for LGBTQIA+ communities requires reimagining and redirecting the purpose, priorities, and power dynamics of technology. Current approaches to AI ethics often fall short because they frame harm as a technical issue rather than a reflection of embedded social injustice. Research shows that addressing bias requires more than audits or datasets; it demands new forms of accountability, collective care, and redistribution (Vecchione et al., 2021).

By grounding ethical AI work in the values of social work and the insights of computational social science, we can move from individual fairness metrics to collective liberation frameworks. LGBTQIA+ communities deserve agency, safety, justice, and, of course, visibility in AI.

2 Meeting and Protecting LGBTQIA+ Needs Using AI

2.1 Health and Mental Health Needs

To effectively support LGBTQIA+ communities, AI systems must be responsive to the complex needs of those they aim to serve. These include addressing mental health disparities, combating violence and hate speech, enhancing educational inclusion, and building safer online and offline spaces for community and care. AI cannot be a “one-size-fits-all” solution. As studies like Tawiah and Monestime (2024) and Bragazzi et al. (2023) emphasized, technology must be attuned to intersecting identities and shaped by community participation at every step, from data collection to design to deployment.

LGBTQIA+ individuals experience disproportionately high rates of depression, anxiety, suicidal ideation, and substance use, compounded by systemic discrimination, stigma, and social exclusion (Rojas et al., 2019; Williams et al., 2021). These disparities are particularly potent for TGNC individuals (Price-Feeney et al., 2020), youth (Wilson & Cariola, 2020), and LGBTQIA+ people of color (Garcia-Perez, 2020; Sutter & Perrin, 2016). Although social work interventions can often address these concerns, structural barriers such as cost, stigma, lack of affirming providers, and language access continue to impede care (Romanelli & Hudson, 2017).

AI technologies offer new opportunities to bridge these gaps. AI-driven chatbots, virtual therapists, and symptom-monitoring systems can expand access to support, especially for people who may not have access to or thrive in traditional mental health service models. Recent research by Ma et al. (2024) found that large language model (LLM)-based chatbots, when designed and attuned to the particular needs of the LGBTQIA+ community, can provide a safe and accessible space for LGBTQIA+ users to discuss mental health concerns. Notably, LGBTQIA+ participants in the study reported appreciating the non-judgmental nature of chatbots and the ability to access support without fear of interpersonal discrimination.

However, these tools also come with risks. Some users noted that LLMs often defaulted to cisnormative or heteronormative assumptions, especially when responding to questions about gender identity or relationships (Ma et al., 2024). This aligns with broader concerns in the literature about algorithmic bias and lack of training data that reflect LGBTQIA+ lived experiences (D'Alfonso, 2020). AI systems trained on non-diverse data can misgender users, fail to recognize culturally specific expressions of distress, or offer inappropriate advice rooted in bias.

One of the most pressing needs identified in recent literature is the development of culturally tailored and linguistically accessible AI tools (Xia et al., 2024). Language is a crucial barrier for many LGBTQIA+ individuals, especially for those who speak languages other than English and for finding services that use up-to-date and appropriate language when referring to the LGBTQIA+ community. Ma et al. (2024) and Fowler et al. (2023) highlighted growing evidence that AI chatbots are most effective when multilingual and culturally adaptive. They argued that translation alone is insufficient and that AI systems must understand and respond to the cultural contexts in which mental health and identity are expressed.

Moreover, the participatory design of these tools is critical. Joyce et al. (2023) proposed a consensus process for developing LGBTQIA+-affirming AI tools, emphasizing the importance of involving diverse stakeholders, including community members, clinicians, and technology developers, in shaping tool functionality and ethical guidelines. Similarly, Joyce et al. (2024) described a toolkit for guiding ethical data practices and community-informed standards for digital mental health interventions.

These frameworks support integrating values-based and person-centered design into AI systems. As digital mental health tools become more prevalent, it is crucial that they not only be accessible but also affirm users' identities and lived experiences.

In sum, AI technologies hold promise for increasing access to mental health care among LGBTQIA+ populations through chatbots and digital interventions. However, their effectiveness depends on attention to cultural responsiveness, linguistic inclusivity, participatory development, and bias mitigation. As social work integrates these tools, practitioners and researchers must ensure that AI-driven care remains affirming, ethical, and grounded in the realities of those it serves.

2.2 Hate Speech and Threat Detection

Machine learning models are being used to detect hate speech, flag threats, and moderate harmful content across social media and online platforms. However, LGBTQIA+ users have long experienced censorship and misclassification by these systems. Terms like "trans," "queer," or "nonbinary" have been flagged as inappropriate content by AI models, while overt hate speech often evades detection. This phenomenon reflects a broader issue of algorithmic bias rooted in training data and sociocultural blind spots.

Research by Chan et al. (2024) demonstrated that hate speech detection models perform best in English and significantly worse across non-English languages—particularly when detecting LGBTQIA+-targeted slurs and harassment. This gap exposes many global LGBTQIA+ communities to unmoderated harm. Similarly, Wong (2024) highlighted that sociocultural context profoundly shapes the expression and detection of hate speech and must be integrated into monitoring systems. Models built on Western conceptions of violence often fail to recognize culturally coded harm in multilingual settings (Ricaurte, 2022).

To address these shortcomings, studies like Reyero Lobo (2022) have proposed knowledge-grounded approaches that incorporate a context-specific understanding of LGBTQIA+ identities and local languages, and have argued that these models perform better at detecting nuanced, culturally embedded threats but require meaningful collaboration with affected communities. Macias et al. (2023) added that preprocessing choices in machine learning pipelines can erase identity markers or misinterpret language, leading to inaccurate or inequitable moderation outcomes.

Ethical design principles must, therefore, guide hate speech detection. Rather than outsourcing safety to black-box machine learning models, both developers and social workers should involve LGBTQIA+ individuals in shaping moderation norms, defining harm, and co-creating hate speech detection logic. Participatory design not only improves accuracy but also builds trust and accountability in the system.

2.3 Predictive Analysis for Safety Planning

Beyond content moderation, AI tools are also being explored for predictive analyses of physical violence. By aggregating public data sources, AI can identify risk hotspots, enabling social workers and community organizers to develop interventions that accurately assess and address the needs of the LGBTQIA+ community. For example, real-time data analytics can reveal spikes in hate-based incidents or geographic patterns of harassment, which can then inform mental health resources, mutual aid hubs, or public awareness campaigns.

However, predictive tools carry the risk of over-policing. AI for safety planning can be most effective when it balances visibility with privacy and is grounded in the self-determined safety strategies of LGBTQIA+ communities. Community-led data collection is one pathway toward ethical and impactful implementation.

2.4 Support Tools for Survivors

AI is also being applied in survivor support platforms, such as mobile apps and chatbots that offer crisis counseling, legal aid, and safety planning (Aldkheel, 2024; Saglam et al., 2024). These tools can enhance access to support for LGBTQIA+ individuals who may hold medical and mental health mistrust due to prior discrimination or fear of being outed. However, the effectiveness of such tools depends on their cultural responsiveness, trauma-informed design, and privacy protections. Survivors from different racial, linguistic, and gender identities may express distress in unique ways that generalized AI systems are ill-equipped to interpret. The work of Dacon et al. (2022) shows that large language models, when appropriately fine-tuned, can effectively engage with diverse expressions of emotion and support, especially when trained on representative data and robust community input.

2.5 Advocacy and Community Building

LGBTQIA+ communities have long relied on digital spaces for identity exploration, social connection, mutual aid, and political mobilization. As AI becomes more integrated into these platforms through content moderation, trend surfacing, and amplification or suppression of voices, it is crucial to ask who these tools serve and whom they silence. AI offers opportunities to strengthen digital advocacy and community building, but it also presents risks of erasure, bias, and harm when designed without LGBTQIA+ participation.

2.6 Strengthening Digital Spaces

Community safety and visibility on online platforms increasingly depend on AI-based moderation systems. Monea (2021) examined how platform algorithms censor LGBTQIA+ expression under the guise of content moderation, a practice described as "digital closet-keeping." Similarly, Simpson and Semaan (2021) found that TikTok's For You Page algorithm created contradictory experiences for LGBTQIA+ users—amplifying preferred types of queer visibility while burying those viewed as "non-normative" or "political."

These findings highlight the need for community-centered moderation frameworks that distinguish between hate speech and LGBTQIA+ self-expression. AI moderation systems can do so by being trained on inclusive data and evaluated for unintended discriminatory effects. Moreover, transparency about moderation logic and avenues for contesting removals can help reclaim digital space for LGBTQIA+ users.

2.7 Supporting LGBTQIA+ Advocacy Through AI-Driven Analysis

AI-powered social media analysis tools are increasingly used to identify public sentiment, track policy conversations, and map discourse around LGBTQIA+ rights. These tools can help organizers understand when and where LGBTQIA+ issues are gaining or losing visibility and support and can inform mobilization.

Bragazzi et al. (2023) emphasized that AI can also support mental health advocacy by monitoring discourse related to LGBTQIA+ well-being, including moments of collective trauma (e.g., anti-LGBTQIA+ legislation or mass violence) or celebration (e.g., Pride events). Real-time AI analytics enable staying attuned to emotional trends within queer communities and responding with tailored care. However, the beneficial impact of AI use in advocacy can be hindered by surveillance logic. Systems that monitor social media sentiment should prioritize privacy, consent, and community ownership, as opposed to policing queer and trans joy, by ensuring that data insights are used to support—not control—marginalized groups.

2.8 Storytelling and Digital Belonging

Beyond moderation and analytics, AI can also elevate LGBTQIA+ narratives through creative applications, such as AI-generated storytelling and digital avatars. Pillis et al. (2024) explored how virtual AI-generated characters can support LGBTQIA+ youth in exploring identity in affirming, low-risk environments. These digital companions offer emotional validation and identity mirroring that many queer individuals lack in their daily lives.

Queer in AI (2023) provides a powerful example of how community-led participatory design can ensure that AI tools reflect the values, voices, and ethics of the communities they intend to serve. Their work demonstrates how intersectional, grassroots collaboration can lead to more effective, ethical, and liberatory AI tools.

2.9 Challenges and Considerations

While AI can support LGBTQIA+ advocacy and community resilience, its benefits are contingent on how, by whom, and for whom it is built. Systems must be designed with attention to the intersectional realities of LGBTQIA+ users, the need for community feedback loops and responsive governance, and the potential for platform bias, data misuse, and algorithmic silencing. AI's role in LGBTQIA+ advocacy is not neutral. It can act as a conduit for collective empowerment or as a mechanism for perpetuating marginalization. To ensure the former, queer and trans people must not only be consulted as users but also empowered as co-creators and stewards of the tools shaping their digital futures.

2.10 Education and Awareness

From curriculum design to student safety policies, students (especially TGNC youth) are disproportionately affected by exclusion, erasure, and discrimination in learning environments. As artificial intelligence becomes increasingly embedded in classrooms, learning platforms, and administrative systems, it presents both opportunities and dangers for LGBTQIA+ students and educators.

2.11 Promoting Inclusion Through AI-Enabled Platforms

AI-driven learning systems are frequently used to personalize education by tailoring content to individual student needs, potentially closing achievement gaps by providing equitable educational opportunities to historically marginalized students (Roshanaei et al., 2023). However, personalization must extend beyond learning style or ability to include cultural identity and gender diversity.

AI systems that recognize and affirm students' names and pronouns and that incorporate diverse examples in their content can help foster inclusion and reduce dropout rates among LGBTQIA+ learners. Yet few platforms are designed with these considerations in mind. As Pawar and Khose (2024) argued, most AI systems are not built with an intersectional lens, which limits their capacity to serve students equitably.

Wong (2024) similarly emphasized the role of AI in STEM education, where LGBTQIA+ students (particularly TGNC youth) face ongoing exclusion. They advocate for inclusive AI tools that normalize queer participation in gatekept fields, as well as curricular tools that actively counteract cisnormative biases in educational content.

2.12 The Risks of Bias and Reinforcement of Inequity

While AI holds promise, it can also reinforce existing biases in education. Barnes and Hutson (2024) warned that educational AI systems trained on biased or incomplete data may perpetuate gendered, racialized, or heteronormative assumptions—from how student performance is assessed to what types of content are deemed appropriate or "neutral." Without careful auditing, these systems risk codifying discriminatory norms under a veneer of technological neutrality.

Viberg et al. (2024) explored how AI-powered educational decision-support systems can embed systemic inequities when developers fail to consider how marginalized groups are represented in their models. They called for a socio-technical approach that includes ethical frameworks, stakeholder input, and mechanisms of institutional accountability to mitigate harm.

These findings are especially urgent in the U.S. context, where LGBTQIA+ (largely TGNC) students are increasingly under attack through state-level legislation that limits access to bathrooms, pronoun usage, healthcare, and inclusive curricula. In this climate, AI systems used in schools must be proactively inclusive to avoid becoming passive tools of marginalization.

2.13 Ethical Design for Inclusive Education Summary

To support LGBTQIA+ inclusion meaningfully, educational AI must be designed with 1) community-led development processes, 2) transparency, 3) feedback mechanisms that allow users to report bias or harm and suggest improvements, and 4) dynamic content generation that adapts to evolving understandings of gender, identity, and equity.

As multiple studies in this review point out, diversity and ethics cannot be retroactive, additive "solutions." They must be embedded in the foundation of AI development in education. Equity-oriented innovation must challenge normative assumptions and reimagine education as a space where all students can thrive.

3 Promoting Ethical and Inclusive AI Usage for the LGBTQIA+ Community

AI systems have occasionally been characterized as less biased than human biases, but in practice, they inherit and amplify the values embedded in their design, data, and deployment (Ntoutsi et al., 2020). For LGBTQIA+ communities, AI's promise of inclusion is too often eclipsed by systems that reproduce structural inequalities and social harm. This section draws on recent work in computational social science, LGBTQIA+ studies, and social work ethics to explore how AI systems replicate bias and how social work-centered ethical frameworks can guide more just and equitable AI development and use.

3.1 Privacy Concerns for LGBTQIA+ Individuals in AI Systems

Artificial intelligence systems depend on vast amounts of data about identities, behaviors, geographies, and interactions. For LGBTQIA+ individuals whose visibility in datasets has often been fraught with risk, this creates both opportunities and obstacles. As AI becomes more integrated into healthcare, social work, education, and public systems, it is critical to examine how data collection, storage, and usage practices can expose LGBTQIA+ people to surveillance, erasure, or unintended harm.

This section explores the ethical implications of AI data practices through the lens of privacy, confidentiality, and client dignity, drawing on social work values and critical data ethics. This section highlights the importance of community-informed data governance, the role of anonymization and data minimization, and the need to move beyond compliance toward transformative data justice.

3.1.1 Surveillance, Misuse, and the Legacy of Data Harm

Historically, LGBTQIA+ individuals have been subject to state, medical, and social surveillance, ranging from pathologizing diagnoses and anti-LGBTQIA+ laws to police monitoring, outing, and algorithmic censorship (Daum, 2019). In the digital age, these forms of surveillance are embedded in datasets, platform analytics, and biometric tools. AI systems trained on such data may not only reflect these harms but amplify them at scale.

Schneider (2022) found that many social work professionals intentionally omit LGBTQIA+ data from records to protect clients from exposure, especially in contexts where disclosure might lead to discrimination, forced outings, or violence. While this may conflict with some data completeness standards in tech development, it aligns with the social work ethic of protecting client autonomy and dignity. This tension reveals the need for AI development guided not just by data efficiency but by relational and harm-reduction ethics.

Hermansyah et al. (2023) further warned that current AI infrastructures are often ill-equipped to ensure data protection for vulnerable communities. They emphasized that ethics cannot be retrofitted. Privacy, especially for LGBTQIA+ people, must be a foundational design principle. Their work calls for a shift from "privacy by default" toward privacy by community co-design, where affected populations shape what data is collected and how it's used.

3.1.2 Anonymization and the Limits of De-Identification

Anonymization is often presented as a solution to data risk, but research shows that de-identified data can still be re-identified, especially when multiple datasets are combined (El Emam et al., 2011). This poses unique risks for LGBTQIA+ individuals who may be the only "out" person in a given ZIP code, demographic group, or service system. Data that seems anonymous on the surface may still reveal queer identity markers.

The Delphi protocol proposed by Joyce et al. (2024) provided a promising approach to this challenge. Their study outlined a participatory tool for assessing AI readiness in LGBTQIA+ mental health contexts, emphasizing the need for community-defined thresholds for data sensitivity. Instead of applying generalized privacy standards, developers should consult with LGBTQIA+ users on what types of information they feel are invasive, harmful, or safe to share.

This is especially important when collecting sexual and gender identity data, which can be highly context-dependent. Joyce et al. noted that trust, choice, and transparency are essential to ethical data collection. LGBTQIA+ individuals must be informed not just about what is collected but why, how long it will be stored, and how it will be used. Without this, even well-intentioned AI tools may reinforce feelings of vulnerability and systemic mistrust.

3.1.3 Social Work Values and the Ethics of Data Stewardship

Some principles of social work (confidentiality, dignity, harm reduction, and empowerment) offer a compelling framework for thinking about ethical AI. As Schneider (2022) argued, these values compel practitioners to evaluate the risks and benefits of data collection critically. When applied to AI, they support the idea that not all data should be collected, nor is it all ethically usable, especially when its use could harm the communities it aims to help.

Radanliev et al. (2024) emphasized this point in their review of ethical AI deployment. They argued that technical safeguards alone are insufficient without an interdisciplinary ethical framework that includes law, social science, and lived experience. Their model called for continuous ethical auditing, scenario testing for harm, and incorporating mechanisms for redress if data is misused. These collaborative processes are essential to move beyond abstract data ethics and into the realm of collective care and accountability.

3.1.4 Building Community-Centered Privacy in AI Systems

To protect LGBTQIA+ users in AI systems, it is crucial to consider informed consent practices beyond legal compliance by supporting meaningful understanding and minimizing the sharing of sensitive data. The field of computational social science can be enhanced by transparency about data flows, storage, and sharing practices. It can do so by applying social work principles to incorporate regulatory models that enable LGBTQIA+ users to influence how data about them is used.

Ethical data practices are not just technical challenges; they are cultural and political commitments. This means working against extractive data logics that treat LGBTQIA+ people as case studies, affirming their rights to digital self-determination and refusal despite the cost to power analyses and sample size. It includes conducting data collection methods that oversample to compensate for these problematic yet essential challenges.

In the age of AI, protecting privacy is not just about safeguarding personal data. It's about honoring identity, dignity, and agency, particularly for communities that have been historically surveilled, erased, or harmed by data systems. LGBTQIA+ individuals deserve more than anonymity; they deserve to be active participants in shaping how technology sees and understands them.

4 Access and Equity in LGBTQIA+ AI Systems

AI is often imagined as a tool of efficiency, but without intentional design, it frequently reproduces the inequities of the systems from which it draws data (Costanza-Chock, 2018). For underrepresented LGBTQIA+ populations, particularly queer and trans people of color (QTPOC), low-income individuals, and those at the intersection of other multiple forms of marginalization, AI systems may be inaccessible, exclusionary, and harmful.

This section draws on critical and intersectional scholarship to examine the barriers to access to AI technologies for marginalized LGBTQIA+ communities, highlighting the technical and sociopolitical challenges to inclusion. Rather than treating access as merely a matter of digital infrastructure or device availability, this section calls for equity through structural design, representational justice, and community voice.

4.1 Exclusion by Design: The Roots of Inaccessibility

Park and Humphry (2019) introduced the concept of "exclusion by design," showing how digital systems often reinforced structural inequities through decisions that seem technical but are deeply political. In their study of smart city technologies and automation, they highlighted how design choices (e.g., language models, user accessibility, and default identity fields) systematically exclude those whose lives don't align with dominant assumptions about gender, race, ethnicity, class, or ability.

For QTPOC or those with limited digital access, AI tools designed without them are alienating. These tools may make inaccurate assumptions about names or pronouns or fail to function on low-bandwidth devices commonly used in lower-income communities. This results in a double exclusion: from the benefits of the technology itself and from the data it uses to improve and adapt.

4.2 The Matrix of Power in AI Fairness Research

Ovalle et al. (2023) critiqued the field of AI fairness for conflating intersectionality with demographic diversity rather than engaging with the matrix of power that shapes people's lived experiences. Their review of 30 fairness-focused papers found that most AI research treats QTPOC individuals as edge cases, if at all.

This superficial treatment of identity often leads to inadequate, irrelevant, or harmful fairness interventions. For example, an AI tool might claim racial equity without acknowledging the compounded effects of being both Black and queer. To address this, the authors proposed an intersectional fairness framework that centers relational, structural, and historical dimensions of oppression (Ovalle et al., 2023).

4.3 Queering the Ethics of AI

Fosch-Villaronga and Malgieri (2023) took this critique further by arguing that AI ethics must be "queered." That is, instead of attempting to plug LGBTQIA+ concerns into existing frameworks, they suggested radically rethinking how AI defines normalcy, legitimacy, and value. Their work critiqued the normative logics of AI development, which presume fixed, binary categories of gender, sexuality, and ability.

Instead, they advocated for a fluid, inclusive ethics framework that embraces multiplicity. This means giving marginalized users power over the design, purpose, and evaluation of AI systems. Such an approach would help dismantle the structures that make AI inaccessible to QTPOC and other multiply-marginalized groups.

4.4 Intersectional AI as Essential Infrastructure

Ciston (2019) echoed this call for radical transformation and proposed that intersectionality is not an add-on to AI development but rather an essential infrastructure. Intersectional design, Ciston argued, can guide every step of the development pipeline, from research framing to interface aesthetics, naming, and addressing power rather than abstracting it away through technical language.

Importantly, Ciston identified that access is also about linguistic accessibility, cultural resonance, safety, and autonomy. A chatbot may be technically available to a transgender Latine teenager. Still, if the chatbot doesn't speak their language, recognize their pronouns, or offer guidance grounded in their lived reality, it's not truly accessible. Intersectional AI pushes us to ask, “Accessible for whom, and at what cost?”

4.5 Educational Gatekeeping and Ethical Literacy

McDonald and Pan (2020) offered an important complement to these arguments in their study of graduate students learning about AI ethics. They found that students often failed to grasp the structural implications of AI bias, defaulting to individualized, decontextualized interpretations of fairness. Thus, if AI developers are not trained to understand systemic inequity, they are unlikely to design tools that serve those at the margins.

This work suggested that ethical AI development must include training on intersectionality, lived experience, and anti-oppressive design, as well as the inclusion of LGBTQIA+ individuals in the development process. This aligns with a growing push in both social work and AI fields to decenter dominant narratives and treat ethical awareness as a collective, community-engaged practice (Raman, 2024).

4.6 Toward Equitable Access: Strategies for Change

AI development must move beyond inclusion to redistribution and co-creation. This can include funding and supporting grassroots AI projects led by LGBTQIA+ people from marginalized backgrounds; redesigning data collection and system training pipelines to reflect lived experiences and avoid the flattening of intersectional identities; creating open-source, low-resource AI tools that are mobile-accessible, multilingual, and culturally grounded; and embedding participatory governance structures that allow LGBTQIA+ users to shape how AI tools are built, deployed, and maintained.

This also means confronting institutional barriers. As McDonald and Pan (2020) showed, the failure to educate developers in structural thinking is a systemic shortcoming. Universities, funders, and tech companies must take responsibility for ensuring that equity is critical, not optional, in AI development.

Access to AI tools is about whether the systems one encounters see, hear, and serve them. For many queer and trans people of color, current AI tools are built on assumptions that exclude, flatten, or pathologize their identities. If we are serious about equity, we must build AI that is not only technically inclusive but structurally accountable. By integrating education on intersectional design frameworks, community-led development, and anti-oppressive ethics into AI infrastructures, we can move toward tools that redistribute power, reflect lived realities, and serve as resources for justice.

5 Future Directions for AI in LGBTQIA+ Social Work

As AI technologies continue to evolve, so too must the frameworks we use to guide their development, deployment, and evaluation. For LGBTQIA+ populations, especially queer and trans people of color, the future of AI in social work is not merely a matter of technical optimization but one of ethical innovation, shared control, and structural transformation.

This section outlines promising directions for AI in LGBTQIA+ social work, emphasizing the need for community-driven evaluation metrics, participatory design, and interdisciplinary collaborations. These strategies ask how LGBTQIA+ people can shape the future of AI.

5.1 Expanding the Role of AI in Social Work Practice

AI offers significant potential to support LGBTQIA+ individuals across domains such as mental healthcare, housing navigation, crisis response, and legal support. Dey (2023) emphasized that AI can enhance service delivery by enabling real-time, need-based responses, for instance, through generative tools that produce personalized referrals or guidance. These tools, deployed with a nuanced understanding of identity, social context, and systemic inequality, can optimize and enhance culturally and individually tailored support.

Lin et al. (2024) further noted that LGBTQIA+ organizations are often excluded from the development of civic tech systems despite their critical role in frontline advocacy and community care. This exclusion reproduces dynamics of marginalization by centralizing technological expertise in academic and practice spaces. Future applications of AI in social work would benefit from a design that centers collaboration with grassroots organizations, ensuring that the technologies developed accurately reflect community needs and values.

5.2 Community-Driven Evaluation Metrics

A critical gap in current AI development is the absence of community-defined success criteria. Too often, AI tools are evaluated using generalized metrics like accuracy, speed, or efficiency—standards that may overlook whether tools actually promote safety, dignity, or empowerment for LGBTQIA+ users.

As argued in this chapter, participatory methods must bring together diverse stakeholders—including LGBTQIA+ individuals, clinicians, developers, and ethicists—to define what success in AI for mental health looks like, thereby enabling more effective and supportive tools. Rather than imposing external standards, this approach grounds evaluation in lived experience and prioritizes collective care over predictive performance.

Similarly, Wan et al. (2023) advocated for community-driven AI development to build trust, improve adoption, and develop tools that work for the people they aim to serve. This work underscored the importance of reparative data practices, in which communities hold power to shape system goals, test outcomes, and govern future iterations.

5.3 Participatory Design as Ongoing Practice

Incorporating community voices into AI development is an ongoing, embedded practice. Lin et al. (2024) showed how community organizations working with LGBTQIA+ youth, people of color, and survivors of violence have developed informal but powerful forms of technological critique and innovation. Formal research and development pipelines rarely capture these insights, but they offer essential feedback for ethical, responsive AI systems.

Future AI development should support participatory research infrastructures, including co-designed workshops for system ideation and testing, feedback loops built into platform interfaces, compensation for community labor in evaluating and improving tools, and public dashboards or zines that make system logic transparent and contestable. These strategies help demystify AI and redistribute power over the systems that increasingly shape people's lives.

5.4 Interdisciplinary Collaborations for Equity and Innovation

No single field can build ethical, effective AI for LGBTQIA+ communities. The future of this work lies in collaborative, interdisciplinary teams that bring together technologists, social workers, technology designers, and, most importantly, community members with lived experience.

As Dey (2023) pointed out, AI developers often lack training in trauma-informed care, intersectionality, and systems of oppression. Similarly, social work practitioners may not be equipped to assess or critically evaluate emerging technologies. Bridging this gap requires mutual education, cross-sector dialogue, and institutional support for truly collaborative knowledge production.

McDonald and Pan (2020) argued that ethical AI development is a pedagogical and political process. Future professionals must be trained to view AI as a social system, engage in reflexive practice, and center marginalized voices at every stage of design. Universities, nonprofits, and tech companies should invest in cross-disciplinary curricula that unite data science, critical theory, and social justice, fund collaborative projects between community organizations and research labs, and support LGBTQIA+ technologists, researchers, and community leaders.

5.5 *Reimagining Success: From Risk Reduction to Liberation*

The most transformative future for AI in LGBTQIA+ social work lies not in risk mitigation alone but in the possibility of liberation. What if AI systems were designed not only to reduce harm but also to amplify queer and trans joy, resilience, and community power?

Centering LGBTQIA+ voices in AI means shifting from reactive (e.g., flagging hate speech) to proactive systems that tell our stories, support collective memory, and help us imagine alternative futures. It means moving from minimizing disparity to maximizing flourishing. And it means defining success by how well AI systems challenge dominant norms.

6 Summary and Calls to Action

Artificial intelligence holds enormous potential to advance equity in social work practice, especially for LGBTQIA+ communities who continue to face systemic barriers to safety, health, education, and visibility. But without intention and ethical design, AI tools risk reinforcing the very harms they hope to solve.

This chapter has outlined both the risks and the possibilities of AI integration, emphasizing the need for community-centered, participatory, and justice-driven approaches. From digital mental health tools to hate speech detection systems, inclusive educational platforms to storytelling technologies, we have shown how AI can either exclude or empower LGBTQIA+ individuals depending on whose voices are included, what values are prioritized, and who holds decision-making power.

This chapter offers three final calls to action:

- *For Technologists, Policymakers, and Researchers*: Prioritizing equity and inclusion at every stage of AI design, deployment, and evaluation can elevate the technology itself and those it serves. LGBTQIA+ communities—especially queer and trans people of color—must not be treated as afterthoughts, edge cases, or data points. Their participation, knowledge, and leadership are essential to creating ethical, inclusive technologies.
- *For the Social Work Profession*: Embrace AI as a tool for advancing social justice while remaining vigilant about its risks. Social workers have a critical role to play in shaping how AI is used to serve vulnerable communities. This means advocating for ethical frameworks, participating in interdisciplinary development, and continuing to prioritize client dignity, privacy, and autonomy.
- *For Social Work Education*: Integrate AI literacy and critical technology studies into social work curricula. As AI becomes more integrated into mental health, housing, child welfare, and other domains, social workers must be prepared to engage with emerging technologies. This includes understanding algorithmic bias, data justice, and participatory design—skills essential for the twenty-first-century practice.

Ethical AI for LGBTQIA+ communities is not only possible—it is necessary. Building it requires deep collaboration across disciplines and unwavering commitment to equity. By grounding our technologies in LGBTQIA+, anti-oppressive, and community-led ethics, we can ensure AI serves innovation and liberation.

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